

On the occasion of Safer Internet Day, February 7, 2023, which is celebrated every year on the second day of the second week of February, the association Collaborators in Learning, CARNET, and the National CERT, along with partners including the Agency for Personal Data Protection, organized a full-day online conference titled "The Quest for a Better Internet." The aim is to send a strong message about the importance of preventing electronic violence, protecting children's personal data, creating a safe virtual environment, and ensuring access to quality online content for children and youth. The importance of protecting personal data is recognized by the General Data Protection Regulation, which stipulates that children deserve special protection regarding their personal data as they may be less aware of the risks, consequences, and protective measures, as well as their rights related to the processing of personal data.

On the topic "Must everyone know who you are? Protect your virtual identity!" a lecture was delivered by Anamarija Mladinić, a representative of the Agency for Personal Data Protection and head of the Legal Advisory, Cooperation, and Projects Department. Most users, especially children, do not read privacy policies on websites and social media and accept all cookies to use services without sufficient awareness of how their personal data is further used and how large technology companies profit precisely from personal data.

Therefore, the representative of the Agency explained why it is important to carefully read notices about which cookies the sites use and for what purposes, as many websites use marketing cookies to display targeted ads and share personal data with third parties, thus generating revenue. Electronic tools (cookies, social plugins, tracking pixels) track browsing habits, what users mark as "likes," and social interactions online to create user profiles, which are then used to tailor ads to specific user interests, i.e., for targeted advertising. However, from the perspective of personal data protection, there are many risks associated with possible insufficient transparency and user control over data, as the processing of personal data based on which targeted messages are displayed is often non-transparent for the individual whose data is being processed.

Additionally, the representative of the Agency touched upon the dangers lurking on the internet that affect not only children but also adults, such as identity theft, malicious software, phishing, electronic violence, hate speech, and more. Therefore, to protect children from all dangers that lurk and to create a safe virtual environment, awareness and education of both children and adults are necessary, as it was noted during the presentation that the biggest violators of children's rights to personal data protection are social networks, as well as parents themselves who post personal data of their own and other children on the internet and in the media, contrary to the best interests of the child (sharenting).

In the concluding part of the lecture, the representative of the Agency spoke about the rights of children guaranteed by the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), which apply to citizens of the Republic of Croatia as well as to all citizens of the European Union. Let us not forget that all children have their legal rights, separate from their parents/guardians, which includes the right to data protection.

The association Collaborators in Learning has been implementing various programs to raise awareness about appropriate, responsible, and safe internet use since 2008, and the program Be Internet Awesome consists of various activities that build on the curriculum Be Internet Awesome, the game Interland, and a series of educational content prepared by the association's mentors for Croatia. "Every school year, workshops for teachers are conducted, either in person at schools or online in the form of webinars and courses that show teachers how they can implement these educational contents and activities in their schools," emphasized Lidija Kralj, head of development at the association Collaborators in Learning.

Also, this year, on the occasion of Safer Internet Day, the association Collaborators in Learning prepared a theater performance Internet Geniuses, which will premiere on Thursday, February 9, 2023, at the Trešnja Theater (Mošćenička 1, Zagreb) starting at 6 PM. The performance is designed for children aged 8 to 12 years, but it will also be interesting for younger and older audiences.

Educational materials from the Agency for Personal Data Protection on the topic of personal data

protection:

How to protect the personal data of children and school employees

Children and youth in the world of modern technologies

How to protect your personal data online

Citizens, know your rights